HEROES AND SAINTS & OTHER PLAYS

Giving Up the Ghost,
Shadow of a Man, Heroes and Saints

Cherríe Moraga

West End Press

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To my heroes,
E.G.
&
R.A.M.

Giving Up the Ghost

A Stage Play in Three Portraits

If I had wings like an angel
over these prison walls
I would fly

(song my mother would sing me)

Giving Up the Ghost had its world premiere on February 10, 1989, at The Studio, Theatre Rhinoceros in San Francisco, with the following cast (in order of appearance):

Marisa	Belinda Ramírez
Corky	Linda Huey
Amalia	Anna Olivarez

It was directed by Anita Mattos and José Guadalupe Saucedo, with sets by Yolanda López, lights by Stephanie Johnson, and sound by Chuy Varela.

An earlier version of *Giving Up the Ghost* was produced by the Front Room Theatre in Seattle. It opened on March 27, 1987, and was directed by Laura Esparza.

The play was developed in part through the "Broadcloth Series" hosted by At the Foot of the Mountain Theatre in Minneapolis. It was given staged readings on June 16 and June 24, 1984, directed by Kim Hines.

Giving Up the Ghost was first published in book form by West End Press of Albuquerque in 1986. This current version of the play is based to a large degree on the Theatre Rhinoceros production.

CHARACTERS

MARISA, *Chicana in her late 20s*
CORKY, MARISA *as a teenager*
AMALIA, *Mexican-born, a generation older than* MARISA
THE PEOPLE, *those viewing the performance or reading the play*

SET

The stage set should be simple, with as few props as possible. A crate is used for street scenes downstage. A raised platform, stage left, serves as the bed in a variety of settings, including a hotel room, a mental hospital, and both AMALIA's *and* MARISA's *apartments. A simple wooden table and two chairs, stage right, represent* AMALIA's *kitchen. Windows, doorways, and furniture appear in the imagination when needed. The suggestion of a Mexican desert landscape is illuminated upstage during scenes evoking indigenous México. Scrims can be used for the dreamlike sequences. Aside from the minimal set pieces mentioned above, lighting and music should be the main features in providing setting. Music should be used to re-create the "streetwise ritmo" of the urban life of these Chicanas, spanning a generation of Motown, soul, Tex-Mex, and Latin rock. It should also reflect the profound influence of traditional Mexican folk music—rancheras, corridos, mariachi, etc.—as well as the more ancient indigenous sounds of the flauta, concha, and tambor. Throughout the long monologues (unless otherwise indicated) when the non-speaking actors remain on stage, the lighting and direction should give the impression that the characters both disappear* and *remain within hearing range of the speaker. In short, direction should reflect that each character knows, on an intuitive level, the minds of the other characters.*

RETRATO I
"La Pachuca"

Prologue

This is the urban Southwest, a Chicano barrio within the sprawling Los Angeles basin. Street sounds fill the air: traffic, children's schoolyard voices, street repairs, etc. MARISA *sits on a wooden crate, centerstage. She wears a pair of Levi's, tennis shoes and a bright-colored shirt. Her black hair is pulled back, revealing a face of dark intensity and definite Indian features. She holds a large sketchbook on her lap.* CORKY *enters upstage. Their eyes meet. As* MARISA's *younger self,* CORKY *tries to act tough but displays a wide open-heartedness in her face which betrays the toughness. She dresses "Cholo style"—khaki pants with razor-sharp creases, pressed white undershirt. Her hair is cut short and slicked back. She approaches the upstage wall, spray can in hand, feigning the false bravado of her teenage male counterparts. She writes in large, Chicano graffiti-style letters, as* MARISA *writes in her sketchbook.*

Dedicación

Don't know where this woman
and I will find each other again,
but I am grateful to her to something
that feels like a blessing

that I am, in fact, not trapped

which brings me to the question of prisons
politics
sex.

CORKY *tosses the spray can to* MARISA.

CORKY (*with* MARISA): I'm only telling you this to stay my hand.

MARISA: But why, cheezus, why me?

Why'd I hafta get into a situation where all my ghosts come to visit?
I always see that man . . . thick-skinned, dark, muscular.
He's a boulder between us.
I can't lift him and her, too . . . carrying him.

He's a ghost, always haunting her . . .
lingering.

Fade out.

Scene One

A Chicano "oldie" rises. Crossfade to CORKY *coming downstage, moving "low and slow" to the tune.*

CORKY: the smarter I get the older I get the meaner I get
tough a tough cookie my mom calls me
sometimes I even pack a blade
no one knows I never use it or nut'ing
but can feel it there there in my pants pocket
run the pad of my thumb over it to remind me I carry somet'ing
am sharp secretly
always envy those batos who get all cut up at the weddings
getting their rented tuxes all bloody
that red 'n' clean color
against the white starched collars
I love that shit!

the best part is the chicks all climbing into the ball of the fight
"¡Chuy, déjalo! Leave him go, Güero!" tú sabes
you know how the chicks get all excited 'n' upset 'n' stuff
they always pulling on the carnales 'n' getting nowhere
'cept messed up themselves 'n' everybody looks so
like they digging the whole t'ing tú sabes
their dresses ripped here 'n' there . . . like a movie
it's all like a movie

when I was a real little kid I useta love the movies
every Saturday you could find me there
my eyeballs glued to the screen
then later my friend Arturo 'n' me
we'd make up our own movies
one was where we'd be out in the desert
'n' we'd capture these chicks 'n' hold 'em up for ransom
we'd string 'em up 'n' make 'em take their clothes off
"strip" we'd say to the wall all cool-like

funny . . . now when I think about how little I was at the time
and a girl but in my mind I was big 'n' tough 'n' a dude
in my *mind* I had all their freedom
the freedom to see a girl kina
the way you see
an animal you know?

like imagining
they got a difernt set
of blood vessels or somet'ing like so
when you mess with 'em
it don' affect 'em the way it do you
like like they got a difernt gland system or somet'ing that
that makes their pain cells
more dense

hell I dunno

but you see
I never could
quite
pull it off

always knew I was a girl
deep down inside
no matter how I tried to pull the other off

I knew
always knew
I was an animal that kicked back . . .

(*with* MARISA) . . . cuz it hurt! (CORKY *exits.*)

MARISA (*from the platform, coming downstage*): I never wanted to be a man, only wanted a woman to want me that bad. And they have, you know, plenty of them, but there's always that one you can't pin down, who's undecided. (*Beat.*) My mother was a heterosexual, I couldn't save her. My failures follow thereafter.

AMALIA (*entering*): I am a failure.

AMALIA *is visibly "soft" in just the ways that* MARISA *appears "hard." She chooses her clothes with an artist's eye for color and placement. They appear to be draped over her, rather than worn: a rebozo wrapped around her shoulders, a blouse falling over the waist of an embroidered skirt. Her hair is long and worn down or loosely braided. As a woman nearing fifty, she gives the impression of someone who was once a rare beauty, now trading that for a fierce dignity in bearing.*

AMALIA: I observe the Americans. Their security. Their houses. Their dogs. Their children are happy. They are not *un* . . . happy. Sure, they have their struggles, their problemas, but . . . it's a life. I always say this, it's a life. (*She sits at the table stacked with art books, puts on a pair of wire-rim glasses, leafs through a book.*)

MARISA: My friend Marta bought her mother a house. I admire her. Even after the family talked bad about her like that for leaving home with a gabacha, she went back cash in hand and bought her mother a casita kina on the outskirts of town. Ten grand was all it took, that's nothing here, but it did save her mother from the poverty her dead father left behind. I envy her. For the first time wished my father'd die so I could do my mother that kind of rescue routine.

I wanna talk about betrayal, about a battle I will never win and never stop fighting. The dick beats me every time. I know I'm not supposed to be sayin' this cuz it's like confession, like still cryin' your sins to a priest you long ago stopped believing was god or god's sit-in, but still confessing what you'd hoped had been forgiven in you. . . . . (*Looking to* AMALIA.) That prison . . . that passion to beat men at their own game.

AMALIA: I worry about La Pachuca. That's my nickname for her. I have trouble calling her by her Christian name. (*Savoring it.*) Marisa. (*"Rain sticks" in the background.*) I worry about La Pachuca. I worry what will happen to the beautiful corn she is growing if it continues to rain so hard and much.

CORKY (*entering*): one time Tury 'n' me stripped for real
there was this minister 'n' his family down the street
they was presbyterians or methodists or somet'ing
you know one of those gringo religions
'n' they had a bunch a kids
the oldest was named Lisa or somet'ing lightweight like that
'n' the littlest was about three or so, named Chrissy
I mean you couldn't really complain about Chrissy
cuz she wasn't old enough yet to be a pain in the cola
but you knew that was coming

Lisa'd be hassling me 'n' my sister Patsy all the time
telling us how we wernt really christians
cuz cath-lics worshipped the virgin mary or somet'ing
I dint let this worry me though cuz we was being tole at school
how being cath-lic was the one true numero uno church 'n' all
so I jus' let myself be real cool with her
'n' the rest of her little pagan baby brothers 'n' sisters

that's all they was to me as far as I was concerned
they dint even have no mass
jus' some paddy preaching up there with a dark suit on
very weird
not a damn candle for miles
dint seem to me that there was any god happening in that place at all

so one day Tury comes up with this idea how we should strip
"for real"
I wasn't that hot on the idea but still go along with him
checkin' out the neighborhood looking for prey
then we run into Chrissy 'n' Tury 'n' me eye each other
the trouble is I'm still not completely sold on the idea
pero ni modo cuz I already hear comin' outta my mouth
real syrupy-like
"come heeeeere Chrissy, we got somet'ing to shoooooow you"
well, a'course she comes cuz I was a big kid 'n' all
'n' we take her into this shed

I have her hand 'n' Tury tells her . . .
no *I* tole her this
I tell her we think she's got somet'ing wrong with her
"down there"
I think . . . I think I said she had a cut or somet'ing
'n' Tury 'n' me had to check it out
so I pull her little shorts down 'n' then her chones
'n' then jus' as I catch a glimpse of her little fuchi fachi . . .
it was so tender-looking all pink 'n' real sweet like a bun
then stupid Tury like a menso goes 'n' sticks his dirty finger on it
like it was burning hot

'n' jus' at that moment . . . I see this little Chrissy-kid
look up at me like . . . like I was her mom or somet'ing
like tú sabes she has this little kid's frown on her face
the chubby skin on her forehead all rumpled up
like . . . like she knew somet'ing was wrong with what we was doing
'n' was looking to me to reassure her
that everyt'ing was cool 'n' regular 'n' all
what a jerk I felt like!
(*She pushes "Tury" away, bends down to "Chrissy".*)

so, I pull up her shorts 'n' whisper to her
"no no you're fine really there's nut'ing wrong with you
but don' tell nobody we looked
we don' want nobody to worry about you"
what else was I supposed to say? ¡Tonta!
'n' Tury 'n' me make a beeline into the alley 'n' outta there!
(*She exits.*)

Scene Two

Crossfade to AMALIA *rising from the bed. It is morning.*

AMALIA: I remember the first time I met her, the day she first began to bring me her work. It was early morning, too early really, and there was someone at the door. At first I think it is my son, Che. Like him to appear at my doorstep with the least amount of warning. (*She goes to the "window," looks down to the front steps.* MARISA *appears, carrying a portfolio.*) But it was Marisa, standing there with a red jacket on, I remember, a beautiful color of red. Maybe if I had not dreamed the color the night before I might not even have bothered to open the door so early, such a hermit I am. (*To* MARISA:) ¿Sí?

MARISA: Hello. I got these . . . paintings. I . . . heard you could help me.

AMALIA: ¿Quién eres?

MARISA: Marisa. Marisa Moreno.

AMALIA: It's a little early ¿qué no?

MARISA: I'm sorry. Frank Delgado—

AMALIA: Súbete.

AMALIA *"buzzes"* MARISA *in.* AMALIA *puts on a robe, brushes back her hair.* MARISA *enters.*

MARISA: Good morning.

AMALIA: It's too early to tell.

MARISA: I'm sorry.

AMALIA: That's two "sorrys" already and I don't even got my eyes on yet.

MARISA: Sor . . .

AMALIA (*smiling*): Pásale. Pásale.

MARISA (*handing her a small paper sack*): Here, this is for you.

AMALIA: Siéntate.

MARISA: It's pandulce.

AMALIA (*looking inside*): Conchas. They're my favorites.

AMALIA *puts the pastry on the table.* MARISA *sits down, holds the portfolio awkwardly in her lap. During the following scene there are brief lapses in the conversation.*

AMALIA: ¿Quieres café?

MARISA: Gracias. No.

AMALIA: Pues, yo . . . sí. (*Goes to prepare the coffee.*) I can't even talk before I have a cup of coffee in me. Help yourself to the pandulce.

MARISA (*indicating the books on the table*): Are all these yours?

AMALIA: The books? Claro.

MARISA: They're wonderful.

AMALIA: Take a look at them if you want.

MARISA *carefully props up her portfolio onto a chair and begins to leaf through one of the books.* AMALIA *reenters, looking for her glasses.*

MARISA: You got a lotta . . . things.

AMALIA: What? Yes. Too much. My son, Che, he calls me a . . . rat pack.

MARISA: A pack rat.

AMALIA: Whatever you call it, I can't even find my glasses.

MARISA (*pointing to the painting on the upstage wall*): And this?

AMALIA: Well, I couldn't afford a room with a view, so . . . bueno, pues I improvised a little. ¿Te gusta? (*She finds her glasses in her robe pocket, puts them on.*)

MARISA: Yeah. Mucho.

AMALIA (*observing her*): You don't seem quite as awesome as Delgado described you.

MARISA: He told you about me?

AMALIA: Ay, all los boys at El Centro were talking about you, telling me how I should see your work . . . this new "Eastlos import."

MARISA: I didn't think they liked me.

AMALIA: Pues, I didn't say they *liked* you.

MARISA: Oh.

AMALIA: I think you scared them a little. Una pintora bien chingona, me dijo Frank.

MARISA: That's what he said?

AMALIA: Más o menos. Bueno. . . . (*Indicating the portfolio.*) Abrélo. Let's see what makes those machos shake in their botas so much.

As MARISA *opens the portfolio, the lights crossfade to* CORKY *entering.*

CORKY: the weird thing was that after that episode with Chrissy
I was like a maniac all summer
snotty Lisa kept harassing me about the virgin mary 'n' all
'n' jus' in general being a pain in the coolie
things began to break down with her 'n' her minister's family
when me 'n' Patsy stopped going to their church meetings
on wednesday nights
we'd only go cuz they had cookies 'n' treats after all the bible stuff
'n' sometimes had arts 'n' crafts where you got to paint
little clay statues of blond jesus in a robe
'n' the little children coming to him
the drag was that you also had to do these prayer sessions
where everybody'd stand in a circle squeezing hands
'n' each kid'd say a little prayer
you know like "for the starving people in china"
Patsy 'n' me always passed when we got squeezed
jus' shaked our heads no
cuz it was against our religion to pray with them
well, one time, this Lisa punk has the nerve to pray that Patsy 'n' me
would (*mimicking*) "come to the light of the one true Christian faith"
shi-it can you get to that? 'course we never went again

AMALIA *puts on an apron, becomes* CORKY's *"mother."*

CORKY: but I remember coming home 'n' telling my mom . . .

"MOTHER": It's better mi'jitas, I think, if you don' go no more.

CORKY: 'n' it was so nice to hear her voice so warm
like she loved us a lot
'n' that night being cath-lic felt like my mom
real warm 'n' dark 'n' kind

Fade out.

Scene Three

At rise, MARISA *straddles the kitchen chair, addresses* THE PEOPLE. AMALIA *is upstage by the bed. During* MARISA's *monologue,* AMALIA *ties her hair back into a tight bun, applies a grey powder to her face, and draws dark circles under her eyes.*

MARISA: The women I have loved the most have always loved the man more than me, even in their hatred of him. I'm queer I am. Sí, soy jota because I have never been crazy about a man. (*Pause.*) My friend Sally the hooker told me the day she decided to stop tricking was when once, by accident, a john made her come. That was strictly forbidden. She'd forgotten to resist, to keep business business. It was very unprofessional . . . and dangerous. No, I've never been in love with a man and I never understood women who were, although I've certainly been around to pick up the pieces. My sister was in love with my brother.

CORKY (*entering*): My mother loved her father.

MARISA: My first woman—

CORKY: The man who put her away.

MARISA: The crazy house. Camarillo, Califas. Sixteen years old.

Blue light. Haunting music. AMALIA *becomes* "NORMA," MARISA's *"first woman." She sits on the bed in a kind of psychotic stupor.* CORKY *goes over to her.* MARISA *narrates.*

MARISA: When I come to get my cousin Norma, she has eyes like saucers, spinning black and glass. I can see through them, my face, my name. She says . . .

"NORMA": I am Buddha.

CORKY: How'd you get that black eye? ¿Quién te pegó?

"NORMA": I am Buddha.

Fade out.

Scene Four

CORKY *is alone on stage. She takes out a yo-yo, tries a few tricks. She is quite good.*

CORKY: since that prayer meeting night
when Patsy 'n' me wouldn't get squeezed into the minister's jesus
Lisa's nose was gettin' higher 'n' higher in the air

one day Patsy 'n' her are playing dolls up
on the second story porch of Mrs. Rodríguez's house
it was nice up there cuz Mrs. R would let you move the tables
'n' chairs 'n' stuff around to play "pertend"

my sister had jus' gotten this nice doll for her birthday
with this great curly hair
Lisa only had this kina stupid doll
with plastic painted-on hair 'n' only one leg
she'd always put long dresses on it to disguise the missing leg
but we all knew it was gone

anyway, one day this brat Lisa throws my sister's new doll
into this mud puddle right down from Mrs. R's porch (*She lets out the yo-yo. It dangles helplessly.*)

Patsy comes back into our yard crying like crazy
her doll's all muddy 'n' the hair has turned bone straight
I mean like an arrow!
I wanted to kill that punk Lisa!
so me 'n' Patsy go over to Lisa's house
where we find the little creep all pleased with herself
I mean not even feeling bad
suddenly I see her bike which is really a trike
but it's huge . . . I mean hu-u-uge!
to this day, I never seen a trike that big
it useta bug me to no end that she wasn't even *trying*
to learn to ride a two-wheeler
so all of a sudden . . . (*Winding up with the yo-yo like a pitcher.*)
that trike 'n' Lisa's wimpiness come together in my mind
'n' I got that thing (*Throwing the pitch.*)
'n' I threw the sucker into the street

I dint even wreck it none (*She stuffs the yo-yo in her back pocket.*)

but it was the principle of the thing

a'course she goes 'n' tells her mom on me
'n' this lady who by my mind don' even seem like a mom
she dint wear no makeup 'n' was real skinny 'n' tall
'n' wore her hair in some kina dumb bun
she has the nerve to call my mom 'n' tell her what I done

AMALIA, *as* CORKY's *"mom," appears upstage in an apron. She is stirring a pot in her arms. She observes* CORKY.

CORKY: so a'course my mom calls me on the carpet
wants to know the story
'n' I tell her 'bout the doll 'n' Patsy 'n' the principle of the thing
'n' Patsy's telling the same story 'n' I can see in my mom's eyes
she don' believe I did nut'ing so bad but she tells me . . .

"MOTHER": We got to keep some peace in the neighborhood, hija.

CORKY: cuz we was already getting pedo from the paddy neighbors
'bout how my mom hollered too much at her kids . . . her own kids!
I mean if you can't yell at your own kids who *can* you yell at?
but she don' let on that this is the real reason
I hafta go over to the minister's house and apologize
she jus' kina turns back to the stove 'n' keeps on
with what she was doing

"MOTHER": Andale, mija, dinner's almost ready. (CORKY *hesitates.*)
Andale. Andale.

CORKY (*coming downstage*): so, a'course I go . . .
I go by myself
with no one to watch me to see if I really do it
but my mom knows I will cuz she tole me to
'n' I ring the doorbell 'n' Mrs. Minister answers
'n' as I begin to talk that little wimp Lisa runs up
'n' peeks out at me from behind her mother's skirt
with the ugliest most snottiest shit-eating grin
I'd ever seen in a person
while all the while *I* say *I'm* sorry
'n' as the door shuts in front of my face
I vow I'll never make that mistake again . . .

(*with* MARISA) I'll never show nobody how mad I can get!

Black out.

Scene Five

MARISA *is pacing about* AMALIA's *room.* AMALIA *sits on the floor mixing paints. She wears a paint-splattered apron.*

MARISA (*to* THE PEOPLE): I have a very long memory. I try to warn people that when I get hurt, I don't forget it. I use it against them. I blame women for everything. My mistakes. Missed opportunities. My grief. I usually leave just when I wanna lay a woman flat. When I feel that vengeance rise up in me, I split. I desert.

AMALIA: Desert. Desierto. For some reason, I could always picture mi cholita in the desert, amid the mesquite y nopal. Always when I closed my eyes to search for her, it was in the Mexican desert that I found her. I *had* intended to take her . . . to México. She would never have gone alone, sin gente allá.

MARISA: This *is* México! What are you talking about? It was those gringos that put up those fences between us!

AMALIA *brings* MARISA *to the table, takes out a piece of charcoal from her apron, puts it into* MARISA's *hand.* MARISA *begins to sketch.*

AMALIA: She was hardly convincing. Her nostalgia for the land she had never seen was everywhere. In her face, her drawings, her love of the hottest sand by the sea.

Coming around behind her, AMALIA *wraps her arms around* MARISA's *neck. Indigenous flutes and drums can be heard in the background.*

AMALIA: Desierto de Sonora. Tierra de tu memoria. (*Turning* MARISA's *face to her.*) Same chata face. Yaqui. (*They hesitate, then kiss their first kiss.*)

MARISA: I've just never believed a woman capable of loving a man was capable of loving . . . me. Some part of me remains amazed that I'm not the only lesbian in the world and that I can always manage to find someone to love me. (*Pause.*) But I am never satisfied because there are always those women left alone . . . and unloved.

Lights slowly fade to black. Musical interlude.

RETRATO II
"La Loca"

Scene Six

A sunny morning. AMALIA *is kneeling on a chair, bent over the table, painting in thick strokes and occasionally sipping at a cup of coffee. Her hair is combed into a braid and tied up.* MARISA *lies on the bed, hands behind her head.*

AMALIA: I've only been crazy over one man in my life. Alejandro was nothing special. Era pescador, indio. Once we took a drive out of the small town he lived in, and he was terrified, like a baby. I'm driving through the mountains and he's squirming in his seat, "Amalia, ¿pa' dónde vamos? Are you sure you know where we're going?" I was so amused to see this big macho break out into a cold sweat just from going no more than twenty miles from his home town. Pero ¡Ay, Dios! How I loved that man! I still ask myself what I saw in him, really. (*Pause.*) He was one of the cleanest people I had ever met. Took two, three baths a day. You have to, you know. That part of la costa is like steam baths some seasons. I remember how he'd even put powder in his shorts and under his huevos to keep dry. He was that clean. I always loved knowing that when I touched him I would find him like a saint. Pure, somehow . . . that no matter where he had been or who he had been with, he would always have washed himself for me. He always smelled . . . so clean. (*She wipes her hands, sits at the foot of the bed.*) When I went back home that first time, after my son was already grown, I had never dreamed of falling in love. Too many damn men under the bridge. I can see them all floating down the river like so many sacks of potatoes. "Making love," they call it, was like having sex with children. They rub your chi-chis a little, then they stick it in you. Nada más. It's all over in a few minutes. ¡Un río de cuerpos muertos!

MARISA: Sometimes I only see the other river on your face. I see it

running behind your eyes. Remember the time we woke up together and your eye was a bowl of blood? I thought the river had broken open inside you.

AMALIA: I was crazy about Alejandro. But what I loved was not so much him . . . I loved his children. I loved the way he had made México my home again. (*Pause.*) He was not a strong man really. He was soft. An inside softness, I could feel even as his desire swelled into a rock hardness. Once he said that with me he felt as though he were "a heart that knew no sex." No man-woman, he meant, only heat and a heart and that even a man could be entered in this way. (*Indigenous music rises in the background.*) I, on the other hand, was *not* clean, forgot sometimes to wash. Not when I was around others, pero con mí misma, I became like the animals. Uncombed. El olor del suelo.

MARISA: I remember the story you told me about the village children, how they had put una muñeca at the door of your casita. How you had found it there . . . there, in your likeness and you thought—

AMALIA: I must be mad.

Suddenly, the beat of tambores. CORKY *enters, wearing a native bruja mask. She dances across the stage with rattles in her hand. As she exits,* MARISA *goes to* AMALIA, *unbraids her hair.*

MARISA: So we take each other in doses. I learn to swallow my desire, work my fear slowly through the strands of your hair.

MARISA *bends to kiss* AMALIA *on the neck.* AMALIA *pulls away, comes downstage.*

AMALIA: Of course, soon after, Alejandro ran to every whore he could find, but not without first calling me that: "puta, bruja." He claimed I was trying to work some kind of mala suerte on him, that I was trying to take from him his manhood, make him something less than a man. (*Pause, to* MARISA:) I have always felt like an outsider.

MARISA *starts toward her, then changes her mind and exits.*

AMALIA (*to* THE PEOPLE): Ni de aquí, ni de allá. Ask me in one word to describe to you the source of all my loneliness and I will tell you, "México." Not that I would have been any happier staying there. How *could* I have stayed there, been some man's wife . . . after so many years in this country, so many years on my own? (*Pause.*) I'll never forget the trip, the day our whole tribe left para el norte.

Sudden spiritedness. A Mexican mariachi instrumental rises. AMALIA *ties a bandana around her head. She is a young girl.*

AMALIA: All of us packed into the old blue Chevy. I was thirteen and la regla had started, the bleeding, and I was ashamed to tell my mother. Tía Fita had been the one to warn me that at my age, any day, I could expect to become sick. "Mala," she said, and that when it happened I should come to her and she would bless me and tell me how to protect myself. It came the morning of our long jornada to California.

AMALIA *sees the "blood" coming down her leg. She takes the bandana from her head, looks around nervously, then stuffs it under her skirt, flattening it back into place.*

AMALIA: Tía Fita was not speaking to my mother so angry was she for all of us leaving. We had asked her to come with us. "What business do I have up there with all those pochos y gringos?" My father said she had no sense. It broke her heart to see us go. So, there was no running to Tía Fita that morning. It seemed too selfish to tell her my troubles when *I* was the one leaving *her.*

Southwestern desert and distant highway sounds can be heard. AMALIA, *trying to hide from the others, pulls the bandana out from under her skirt. Kneeling by the "river," she secretly begins to wash the blood from it. Sound and lights gradually fade out.*

Scene Seven

MARISA *sits at the table in soft light sipping at a beer. She is dressed for the evening in a man's suit jacket. She wears a kind of classic androgynous look.* AMALIA *enters in a slip, crosses to the bed where she begins to dress.*

MARISA: If I were a man, things would've been a lot simpler between us, except . . . she never would've wanted me. I mean, she would've seen me more and all, fit me more conveniently into her life, but she never would've, tú sabes . . . wanted me.

AMALIA: Sometimes I think, with me, that she only wanted to feel herself so much a woman that she would no longer be hungry for one. Pero, siempre tiene hambre. Siempre tiene pena.

MARISA: She'd come to me sometimes I swear like heat on wheels. I'd open the door and find her there, wet from the outta nowhere June rains, and, without her even opening her mouth, I knew what she

had come for. I never knew when to expect her this way, just like the rains. Never ever when I wanted it, asked for it, begged for it, only when she decided.

AMALIA: I always had to have a few traguitos and then things would cloud between us a little and I could feel her as if underwater, my hands swimming towards her in the darkness, discovering breasts, not mine . . . not these empty baldes, pero senos firmes, like small stones of heat. Y como un recién nacido, I drink and drink and drink y no me traga la tierra.

Lights suggest memory. Nighttime freeway sounds, car radio music. MARISA *and* AMALIA *hold each other's eyes. Voice over.*

MARISA: I'll keep driving if you promise not to stop touching me.

AMALIA: You want me to stop touching you?

MARISA: No, if you promise *not* to stop.

AMALIA *crosses in front of* MARISA. *She prepares herself a drink.* MARISA *watches her.*

MARISA: It's odd being queer. It's not that you don't want a man, you just don't want a man in a man. You want a man in a woman. The woman part goes without saying. That's what you always learn to want first. Maybe the first time you see your dad touch your mom in that way . . .

CORKY (*entering*): ¡Hiiiijo! I remember the first time I got hip to that! My mom standing at the stove making chile colorado and flippin' tortillas. She asks my dad . . .

AMALIA (*as* "MOM," *to* MARISA): ¿Quieres otra, viejo?

CORKY: Kina like she's sorta hassled 'n' being poquita fría, tú sabes, but she's really digging my dad to no end. 'N' jus' as she comes over to him, kina tossing the tort onto the plate, he slides his hand, real suave-like, up the inside of her thigh. Cheezus! I coulda died! I musta been only about nine or so, but I got that tingling, tú sabes, that now I know what it means.

As CORKY *exits, she throws her chin out to* MARISA *"bato style."* MARISA, *amused, returns the gesture. The lights shift.* MARISA *puts on a tape. A Mexican ballad is played—"Adios Paloma" by Chavela Vargas.* AMALIA *hums softly along with it.*

MARISA: Hay un hombre en esta mujer. Lo he sentido. La miro, cocinando para nosotras. Pienso . . . ¿cómo puede haber un hombre en una persona, tan feminina? Su pelo, sus movimientos de una serenidad imposible de describir.

AMALIA (*softly singing*):

'Ya se va tu paloma, mi vida
lleva en sus alas dolor
lleva en sus ojos tristeza
y es un lamento su voz.'

MARISA (*going to her*): Tu voz que me acaricia con cada palabra . . . tan suave . . . tan rica. (*Takes her by the hand.*) Vente.

The music rises. They dance for a few moments, then MARISA *takes* AMALIA *to the bed. The music fades as* MARISA *slowly removes* AMALIA*'s blouse.*

MARISA: Con ella, me siento como un joven lleno de deseo. I move on top of her. She wants this. The worn denim and metal buttons are cotton and cool ice on my skin. And she is full of slips and lace and stockings . . .

AMALIA: Quítate los pantalones.

MARISA: And yet it is she who's taking me.

A soft jazz rises. MARISA *takes off her jacket. They kiss each other, at first tenderly, then passionately. They hold and caress each other.* MARISA *takes* AMALIA*'s hand, brings it to her chest. The music softens.*

MARISA: I held the moment. Prayed that if I looked long and hard enough at your hand full inside me, if I could keep this pictured forever in my mind . . . how beneath that moon blasting through the window, . . . how everything was changing at that moment in both of us.

AMALIA: How everything was changing . . . in both of us.

The jazz rises again. The lights slowly fade as they hold a deep kiss.

RETRATO III
"La Salvadora"

Scene Eight

CORKY *writes graffiti-style on upstage wall.*

I have this rock in my hand
it is my memory
the weight is solid
in my palm it cannot fly away

because I still remember
that woman
not my savior, but an angel
with wings
that did once lift me
to another
self.

MARISA *and* AMALIA *appear in shadow on opposite ends of the stage.*

AMALIA: You have the rest of your life to forgive me.

MARISA: Forgive you for what?

AMALIA: Por lo que soy.

Black out.

Scene Nine

AMALIA *enters carrying a small suitcase. She sets it down at the foot of the bed, removes her rebozo and holds it in her lap.*

AMALIA: All I was concerned about was getting my health back together. It was not so much that I had been sick, only I lacked . . . energy. My body felt like a rag, squeezed dry of any feeling. Possibly it was the "change" coming on. But the women in my family did not go through the change so young. I wasn't even fifty. I thought . . . maybe it was the American influence that causes the blood to be sucked dry from you so early. Nothing was wrong with me, really. My bones ached. I needed rest. Nothing México couldn't cure.

She lies down, covers herself with the rebozo. MARISA *enters, barefoot.*

MARISA: For the whole summer, I watched the people fly in bright-colored sails over the Califas sea, waiting for her. Red- and gold- and blue-striped wings blazing the sky. Lifting off the sandy cliffs, dangling gringo legs. Always imagined myself up there in their place, flying for real. Never ever coming back down to earth, just leaving my body behind. (*Pause.*) One morning I awoke to find a bird dead on the beach. I knew it wasn't a rock because it was light enough to roll with the tide . . . I saw this from a distance. Later that day, they found a woman dead there at the very same spot, I swear. Una viejita. (*A soft grey light washes over* AMALIA.) A crowd gathered 'round her as a young man in a blue swimsuit tried to spoon the sand from her throat with his finger. Putting his breath to her was too late. She was so very very grey and wet, como la arena . . . y una mexicana, I could tell by her house dress. How did she drown? Then I remembered what Amalia had told me about bad omens. (*A sudden ominous tambor,* AMALIA *bolts up in bed.*) I stopped going. I stopped waiting.

MARISA *exits.*

AMALIA: When I learned of Alejandro's death, I died too. I just started bleeding and the blood wouldn't stop, not until his ghost had passed through me or was born in me. I don't know which. That Mexican morning I had awakened to find the hotel sheets red with blood. It had come out in torrents and thick clots that looked like a fetus. But I was not pregnant, my tubes had been tied for years. Yet, lying there in the cool dampness of my own blood, I felt my womanhood leave me. And it was Alejandro being born in me. Does this make sense? I can't say exactly how I knew this, except . . . again . . . for the smell, the unmistakable smell of the man, as if we had just made love. And coming from my mouth was *his* voice . . . "¡Ay mi Marisa! ¡Te deseo! ¡Te deseo!" (*Her eyes search for* MARISA.) Marisa!

Lights rise. Morning in Mexico City. AMALIA *gets up from the bed.*

AMALIA: It is barely dawn and the sun has already entered my hotel window. Afuera los hombres are already at work tearing up the Mexican earth with their steel claws. (*Indigenous music.*) Pero La Tierra is not as passive as they think. "Regresaré," Ella nos recuerda. "Regresaré," nos promete. When they "discovered" El Templo Mayor beneath the walls of this city, they had not realized that it was She who discovered them. Nothing remains buried forever. Not even memory. Especially not memory.

Fade out.

Scene Ten

The indigenous music blends into Chicano urban sounds. MARISA *enters. Her posture is noticeably more guarded than in the previous scene. The music fades. There is a pause as* MARISA *scans the faces of* THE PEOPLE.

MARISA: Got raped once. When I was a kid. Taken me a long to say that was exactly what happened, but that was exactly what happened. Makes you more aware than ever that you are one hunerd percent female, just in case you had any doubts. One hunerd percent female whether you act it . . . or like it . . . or not. Y'see, I never ever really let myself think about it, the possibility of rape, even after it happened. Not like other girls, I didn't walk down the street like there were men lurking everywhere, every corner, to devour me. Yeah, the street was a war zone, but for different reasons, . . . for muggers, mexicanos sucking their damn lips at you, gringo stupidity, drunks like old garbage sacks thrown around the street, and the rape of other women and the people I loved. They weren't safe and I worried each time they left the house . . . but never, never me. I guess I never wanted to believe I was raped. If someone took me that bad, I wouldn't really want to think I was took, you follow me? But the truth is . . .

CORKY (*entering*): I was took

MARISA *crosses to the platform.* CORKY *"stakes out the territory."*

CORKY: I was about twelve years old
I was still going to cath-lic school then
'n' we wore those stupid checkered jumpers
they looked purty shitty on the seventh 'n' eighth grade girls
cuz here we was getting chi-chis 'n' all

'n' still trying to shove 'em into the tops of these play suits
I wasn't too big pero the big girls looked terrible!

anyway in the seventh grade I was trying to mend my ways
so would hang after school 'n' try to be helpful 'n' all to the nuns
I guess cuz my cousin Norma got straight A's
'n' was taking me into her bed by then
so I figured . . . that was the way to go
she'd get really pissed when I fucked up in school
threatened to "take it away" tú sabes if I dint behave
can you get to that? ¡Qué fría! ¿no?

anyway Norma was the only one I ever tole
about the janitor doing it to me
'n' then she took it away for good
I'd still like to whip her butt for that
her 'n' her goddamn hubby 'n' kids now shi-it
puros gabachos, little blond-haired blue-eyed things
the oldest is a little joto if you ask me
sure he's barely four years old but you can already tell
the way he goes around primping all over the place
pleases me to no end
what goes around comes around
"Jason" they call him
no, not "Ha-són" pero "Jay-sun"
puro gringo

anyway so I was walking by Sister Mary Dominic's classroom
"the Hawk" we called her cuz she had a nose 'n' attitude like one
when this man a mexicano motions to me to come on inside
"Ven p'aca," he says
I dint recognize him but the parish was always hiring
mexicanos to work around the grounds 'n' stuff
I guess cuz they dint need to know English
'n' the priests dint need to pay 'em much
they'd do it "por Dios" tú sabes
so he asks me, "Señorita, ¿hablas español?" muy polite y todo
'n' I answer, "Sí poquito," which I always say to strangers
cuz I dunno how much they're gonna expect outta me
"Ven p'aca," he says otra vez
'n' I do outta respect for my primo Enrique
cuz he looks a lot like him but somet'ing was funny
his Spanish I couldn't quite make it out cuz he mumbled alot
which made me feel kina bad about myself tú sabes
that I was Mexican too but couldn't understand him that good

he's trying to fix this drawer that's loose in the Hawk's desk
I knew already about the drawer

cuz she was always bitchin' 'n' moanin'
about it getting stuck cuz the bottom kept falling out
so he tells me he needs someone to hold the bottom of the drawer up
so he can screw the sides in
(*She goes to the "desk," demonstrates.*)
so standing to the side I lean over
and hold the drawer in place así
then he says all frustrated-like, "No, así, así."
it turns out he wants me to stand in front of the drawer
with my hands holding each side up así
(*She stands with her legs apart, her pelvis pressed up against the edge of the "desk."*)
'n' believe it or not this cabrón sits behind me on the floor
'n' reaches his arm up between my legs
that I'm straining to keep closed
even though he keeps saying all business-like
"Abrete más por favor las piernas. Abretelas un poco más."
'n' like a pendeja I do

(*She grips the edge of the "desk."*)
I feel my face getting hotter
'n' I can kina feel him jiggling the drawer
pressed up against me down there
I'm staring straight ahead don' wanna look at what's happening
then worry how someone would see us like this
this guy's arm up between my legs
'n' then it begins to kina brush past the inside of my thigh
I can feel the hair that first
then the heat of his skin
(*Almost tenderly.*) the skin is so soft I hafta admit
young kina like a girl's like Norma's shoulder
I try to think about Norma 'n' her shoulders
to kina pass the time hoping to hurry things along
while he keeps saying, "Casi termino. Casi termino."
'n' I keep saying back, "Señor me tengo que ir, mi mamá me espera."
still all polite como mensa!
until finally I feel the screwdriver by my leg like ice
then suddenly the tip of it it feels like to me
is against the cotton of my chones

"Don't move," he tells me. In English. His accent gone. 'n' I don'

from then on all I see in my mind's eye . . .
were my eyes shut?
is this screwdriver he's got in his sweaty palm
yellow glass handle
shiny metal

the kind my father useta use to fix things around the house
remembered how I'd help him how he'd take me on his jobs with him
'n' I kept getting him confused in mind
this man 'n' his arm with my father
kept imagining he was my father returned come back
the arm was so soft but this other thing . . .
hielo hielo ice!
I wanted to cry, "¡Papi! ¡Papi!"
'n' then I started crying for real
cuz I knew I musta done somet'ing real wrong
to get myself in this mess

I figure he's gonna shove the damn thing up me
he's trying to get my chones down, "Por favor señor please don'."
but I can hear my voice through my own ears
not from the inside out but the other way around
'n' I know I'm not fighting this one
I know I don' even sound convinced
"¿Dónde 'stás, papi? ¿Dónde 'stás?"
'n' finally I hear the man answering, "Aquí estoy. Soy tu papá."
'n' this gives me permission to go 'head to not hafta fight

by the time he gets my chones down to my knees
I suddenly feel like I'm floating in the air
my thing kina attached to no body
flapping in the wind like a bird a wounded bird
I'm relieved when I hear the metal drop to the floor
only worry *who will see me doing this?*
(*Gritting her teeth.*) *get-this-over-with-get-this-over-with*
'n' he does gracias a dios bringing me down to earth

linoleum floor cold
the smell of wax
polish

y ya 'stoy lista for what long ago waited for me
there is no surprise
'n' I open my legs wide wide open
for the angry animal that springs outta the opening in his pants
'n' all I wanna do is have it over so I can go back to being myself
'n' a kid again

then he hit me with it
into what was supposed to be a hole
(*Tenderly.*) that I remembered had to be
cuz Norma had found it once wet 'n' forbidden
'n' showed me too how wide 'n' deep like a cueva hers got
when she wanted it to only with me she said

MARISA: Only with you, Corky.

CORKY: but with this one there was no hole he had to make it
'n' I saw myself down there like a face with no opening
a face with no features
no eyes no nose no mouth
only little lines where they shoulda been
so I dint cry
I never cried as he shoved the thing
into what was supposed to be a mouth
with no teeth
with no hate
with no voice
only a hole
a hole!

He made me a hole!

MARISA *approaches, wraps a rebozo around* CORKY's *shoulders, holds her.*

MARISA: I don't regret it. I don't regret nuthin'. He only convinced me of my own name. From an early age you learn to live with it, being a woman. I just got a head start over some. And then, years later, after I got to be with some other men, I admired how their things had no opening . . . only a tiny tiny pinhole dot to pee from, to come from. I thought . . . how lucky they were, that they could release all that stuff, all that pent-up shit from the day, through a hole that *nobody* could get into.

Scene Eleven

MARISA *and* CORKY *remain on stage. The lighting slowly shifts. Indigenous music, lively tambores.* AMALIA *enters wearing a rebozo. She covers* MARISA's *shoulders with one as well. All three, now in rebozos, have become indias. They enter a dream.* CORKY *comes downstage, kneels. She begins making tortillas, slapping her hands together.* MARISA *and* AMALIA *join her on each side, forming a half circle. They, too, clap tortillas to the rhythm of the tambores. They are very happy. The rhythm quickens, accelerates.*

MARISA *and* AMALIA *slowly bend toward each other, their faces crossing in front of* CORKY's. *They kiss. Suddenly the scene darkens, the drumming becomes sinister, the clapping frantic. Thunder. Lightning. The gods have been angered. The three scatter. The stage is a maze of colliding lights, searching out the women.* CORKY *has disappeared.* AMALIA *cowers beneath her rebozo.* MARISA *appears upstage in shadow. She is out of breath. She is being hunted, her arms*

spread, her body pressed up against an invisible wall.

MARISA: Amalia, let me in! ¡Abre la puerta! ¡Vienen a agarrarme!

AMALIA *wrestles in bed with her "pesadilla."*

MARISA: ¡No me dejes, Amalia! ¡No me dejes sola! Let me in!

AMALIA *can't bear to hear her, covers her ears.*

MARISA: Amalia! . . . Amalia! . . . Let . . . me . . . in!

The lights fade out and rise again. CORKY *can be seen in shadow standing where* MARISA *had been seconds before. She holds a beer bottle in the air above her head. She comes down with it, like a weapon. The sound of glass breaking. Black out.*

AMALIA (*in the darkness*): ¿Quién es? ¿Quién es? Who is it? ¿Eres tú, Che?

Lights rise. AMALIA *is sitting up in bed. There is an opened, unpacked suitcase on the floor and a photo of a man with a candle next to it on the table.* MARISA *appears in the doorway. She is very drunk, almost in a stupor.*

AMALIA: Marisa.

MARISA: Where the . . . where have you been? (AMALIA *gets out of bed, puts on a robe.*)

AMALIA: What are you doing here?

MARISA (*menacingly*): I'm asking you a question.

AMALIA: Don't come near me.

MARISA: I said, where have you been?

AMALIA: What do you want?

MARISA: I wanna know . . . (*She stalks* AMALIA.) I wanna know where you been.

AMALIA: You're drunk.

MARISA: Good observation, maestra. Now are you gonna answer me?

AMALIA: Stay away from me. Don't touch me.

MARISA: I'm not gonna touch you. No, no. These hands? No, no, Doña Amalia . . . us jotas learn to keep our hands to ourselves.

AMALIA: ¡Adió!

MARISA: Answer me!

AMALIA: You know where I was.

MARISA: I waited for you. I waited three goddamn months! Count them! June, July—

AMALIA: I can count.

MARISA: Well, jus' cuz it aint all hanging out on the outside don' mean I don' feel nuthin'. What did you expect from me anyway?

AMALIA: Well, not this.

MARISA: Well, honey, this is what you got. Aint I a purty picture?

AMALIA: Estás borracha. Estás loca.

MARISA: Bueno, 'stoy loca. Tal vez quieres que te hable en español, eh? A lo mejor you could understand me then. I'm sorry, y'know, us pochas don' speak it as purty as you do.

AMALIA: What are you talking about?

MARISA: I'm talking about going to the goddamn mailbox every day, thinking every llamadita would be you. "Ven, Chatita. Meet me in México." You lied to me.

AMALIA: I didn't lie.

MARISA: No?

AMALIA: No. (*She turns away.*)

MARISA: What then?

There is a pause.

MARISA: Look at you. You don' got nuthin' to say to me. You don' feel

a thing.

AMALIA: It's three o'clock in the morning, what am I supposed to feel?

MARISA (*after a beat*): Nuthin'. You're supposed to feel nuthin'.

AMALIA: I'm going to get you some coffee.

MARISA: I don' want no coffee! You went back to him, didn't you?

AMALIA: Ay, Marisa, por favor no empieces.

MARISA (*seeing the photo*): What is this? A little altar we have for the man? (*She picks it up.*)

AMALIA: Don't.

MARISA: ¡Vela y todo! What is he, a saint now?

AMALIA: ¡Déjalo!

MARISA: You're still in love with him, aren't you?

AMALIA: Put it down, te digo.

MARISA (*approaching*): I'm asking you a question.

AMALIA: Stay away from me.

MARISA: Answer me! (*Grabs* AMALIA.) Are you in love with him or not?

AMALIA: ¡Déjame!

MARISA (*shaking her*): Did you sleep with him?

AMALIA: No! Stop it!

MARISA: Did you? Tell me the truth!

AMALIA: No! ¡Déjame! (*They struggle. The picture falls to the floor.* AMALIA *breaks* MARISA's *hold.*) I'm not an animal! What gives you the right to come in here like this? Do you think you're the only person in the world who's ever been left waiting?

MARISA: What was I supposed to think . . . that you were dead? That you were dead or you were with him, those were my two choices.

AMALIA (*bitterly*): He's the one who's dead.

MARISA (*after a pause*): What?

AMALIA: He's dead.

AMALIA *slowly walks over to the picture, picks it up, replaces it by the candle. She sits down on the bed, her face impassive.*

AMALIA (*after a pause*): When I got the news, I was in a hotel in Mexico City. I didn't stop to think about it, I took a bus right away to la Costa. Then I hired a boy to give me a lift in a truck. When I got to the river, I knew where to go. The exact spot. The place under the tamarindo where we used to make love. And for hours until dark I sat there by la orilla as I imagined he had that last time.

MARISA: He drowned.

AMALIA: He drowned himself.

MARISA (*going to her*): It's not your fault, Amalia.

AMALIA (*after a pause*): Whose face do you think he saw in the belly of that river moments before it swallowed him?

MARISA: It's not your fault. (*There is a long silence.* MARISA *makes a gesture to touch* AMALIA, *but is unable to.*) I shouldn't have come. I'm sorry.

AMALIA: No, stay. Stay and keep an old woman company.

MARISA: I'll come back tomorrow . . . fix the window. (*She starts to exit.*)

AMALIA: Soñé contigo.

MARISA: You did?

AMALIA: Last night. (*Pause.*) I dreamed we were indias. In our village, some terrible taboo had been broken. There was thunder and lightning. I am crouched down in terror, unable to move when I realize it is *you* who have gone against the code of our people. But I was not afraid of being punished. I did not fear that los dioses would enact their wrath against el pueblo for the breaking of the taboo. It was merely that the taboo *could* be broken. And if this law nearly transcribed in blood could go, then what else? What *was* there to hold to? What immutable truths were left? (*Pause. She turns to*

MARISA.) I never wanted you the way I wanted a man. With a man, I just would have left him. Punto. (*Pause.*) Like I left Alejandro.

The lights slowly fade to black.

Scene Twelve

MARISA *sits on the platform.* AMALIA's *rebozo has been left there.*

MARISA: I must admit I wanted to save her. That's probably the whole truth of the story. And the problem is . . . sometimes I actually believed I could, and *sometimes* she did too.

She was like no woman I had ever had. I think it was in the quality of her skin. Some people, you know, their skin is like a covering. They're supposed to be showing you something when the clothes fall into a heap around your four ankles, but nothing is lost, y'know what I mean? They jus' don' give up nuthin'. Pero Amalia . . . ¡Híjole!

She picks up AMALIA's *rebozo, fingers it.*

She was never ever fully naked in front of me, always had to keep some piece of clothing on, a shirt or something always wrapped up around her throat, her arms all outta it and flying. What she did reveal, though, each item of clothing removed was a gift, I swear, a small offering, a suggestion of all that could be lost and found in our making love together. It was like she was saying to me, "I'll lay down my underslip. ¿Y tú? ¿Qué me vas a dar?" And I'd give her the palm of my hand to warm the spot she had just exposed. Everything was a risk. Everything took time. Was slow and deliberate.

I'll never forget after the first time we made love, I was feeling muy orgullosa y todo, like a good lover, and she says to me—

AMALIA (*voice-over, memory*): You make love to me like worship.

MARISA: And I nearly died, it was so powerful what she was saying. And I wanted to answer, "Sí, la mujer es mi religion." If only sex coulda saved us.

Y'know, sometimes when me and her were in the middle of it, making love, I'd look up at her face, kinda grey from being indoors so much with all those books of hers, and I'd see it change, turn this real deep color of brown and olive, like she was cooking inside. Tan linda. Kind. Very very very kind to me, to herself, to the pinche planet . . . and I'd watch it move from outside the house where

that crazy espíritu of hers had been out makin' tracks. I'd watch it come inside, through the door, watch it travel all through her own private miseries and settle itself, finally, right there in the room with us. This bed. This fucking dreary season. This cement city. With us. With me. No part of her begging to have it over . . . forget. And I could feel all the parts of her move into operation. Waiting. Held. Suspended. Praying for me to put my tongue to her and I knew and she knew we would find her . . . como fuego. And just as I pressed my mouth to her, I'd think . . . *I could save your life.*

(*Coming downstage.*) It's not often you get to see people this way in all their pus and glory and still love them. It makes you feel so good, like your hands are weapons of war. And as they move up into el corazón de esta mujer, you are making her body remember, it didn't have to be that hurt. ¿Me entiendes? It was not natural or right that she got beat down so damn hard, and that all those crimes had nothing to do with the girl she once was two, three, four decades ago.

Pause. Music rises softly in the background.

MARISA: It's like making familia from scratch
each time all over again . . .
with strangers, if I must.
If I must, I will.

I am preparing myself for the worst
so I cling to her in my heart
my daydream with pencil in my mouth

when I put my fingers
to my own forgotten places.

The lights gradually fade out. Music.

End